

143 Make a feather collection

20
MINS

Birds come in a variety of shapes and sizes. One of the most striking things about birds is their plumage. Some are brightly colored, others are drab. Discover the wonder of feathers for yourself by starting a collection.

What you need

- Feathers
- Field guide to birds

1 Try to find clean-looking, whole feathers. Discard any that are broken, have ragged edges, or have chunks missing from them.

2 Use a field guide to identify which species of bird a feather belongs to. Look for clues in terms of color, stripes, or speckles to help you match the feather to the bird.

Central shaft

3 Try to work out which part of the bird the feather comes from. Long, slender ones are likely to be tail feathers, while small ones with down at the base are body feathers.

Striped tail feather

Body feather

DUCK

GOOSE

PHEASANT

KESTREL

JAY

144 Unzip a feather

3
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Starting at the tip, run your fingers down a feather to “unzip” it. This makes it looked ragged. Now run your fingers up it from base to tip, “zipping” it back. The barbs in the feather cling together and make it waterproof.

Barbs

